

Master Story Plan

Overview

This Master Story Plan documents the narrative architecture of a 10-component digital storytelling campaign for HackPGH, Pittsburgh's first and oldest volunteer-run makerspace and a registered 501(c)(3) nonprofit organization. Founded in 2009 and located in Pittsburgh's Uptown neighborhood, HackPGH provides tools, training, and community to makers of all backgrounds.

The campaign is organized around this angle:

"HackPGH is one of Pittsburgh's last genuinely open community spaces, built by volunteers, sustained by curiosity, and available to anyone willing to show up."

This draws on HackPGH's own "Third Place Makerspace" initiative, which frames the organization as a low-cost or free gathering space between home and work. This is a concept brought up by sociologist Ray Oldenburg and adopted by HackPGH to describe its aspirational role in Pittsburgh's civic life.

The Communication Problem

Despite 15+ years of operation and a compelling mission, HackPGH's public narrative remains underdeveloped. An audit of their digital presence reveals a content strategy focused primarily on event calendar announcements rather than experiential storytelling, showing what is happening but not what it feels like to be there. Social media engagement is low relative to the organization's longevity, and member testimonials or user-generated content are largely absent.

The result is that most Pittsburghers are either unaware HackPGH exists or assume it is not meant for them. This campaign exists to close that gap by telling the human story behind the space.

Target Audiences & Persona Overview

Three distinct audience personas shape the campaign's messaging strategy, each representing a different relationship to HackPGH and requires a different entry point into the Third Place narrative.

Maya, 31 (Creative Professional)

Graphic designer in Lawrenceville. Moderate income, craves hands-on community outside screen-based work. Unaware HackPGH exists or assumes it's only for engineers. Active on Instagram and local Pittsburgh Reddit. Campaign goal: convert to first-time visitor.

Will, 19 (Underserved Maker)

Recent high school grad from Homewood. Mechanically curious but cannot afford the \$75/month membership. Does not see himself in HackPGH's current marketing. Active on TikTok and YouTube. Campaign goal: raise awareness of scholarships and belonging.

Linda, 48 (Community Funder)

Program officer at a Pittsburgh community foundation. Evaluates nonprofits for grants. Needs clear evidence of equity focus and community impact. Reads LinkedIn and nonprofit sector publications. Campaign goal: position HackPGH as grant-worthy.

Narrative Structure

The campaign constructs a three-part narrative across its 10 components to establish the problem, introduce the solution through human experience, and call the audience to action.

1. Establish the exigence: community spaces are disappearing, and most people don't know a place like HackPGH exists. The infographic and campaign proposal anchor this act with data and context, while the Master Story Plan documents the strategy.
2. Show what HackPGH actually feels like from the inside. The audio story, visual narrative, promotional video, and visual audit all center on people (their voices, faces, hands, and creations). This is where the Third Place concept becomes tangible rather than abstract.
3. Move each audience from awareness to action. The social media series, campaign landing page, and pitch presentation each serve as entry points, telling the audience there is a place for them at HackPGH and making it easy to take the next step.

Component-by-Component Story Map

1. Campaign Proposal: Establishes the research foundation and narrative north star for the entire campaign.
2. Visual Audit: Establishes a warm, accessible visual identity and ensures every component feels cohesive and human.
3. Master Story Plan (this): Behind-the-scenes blueprint documenting narrative structure, audience journey, and production rationale.
4. Infographic: Presents data on loneliness, decline of third places, HackPGH's 15+ years of impact and accessibility programs.

5. Visual Narrative: Shows hands, tools, faces, and finished work together. Argues visually that HackPGH is a human space and not just a technical one.
6. Video: Opens with the problem (disappearing community spaces), resolves with HackPGH as the answer.
7. Audio Narrative: The component that lets audiences hear the community, not just see it.
8. Social Media Adaptation: Platform-specific entry points: Instagram for visuals, LinkedIn for the equity argument. Each post is a different door into the same story.
9. Pitch Presentation: Presents the campaign to HackPGH as a simulated client.
10. Portfolio Site: The campaign hub hosting the components.

Audience Journey Map

Maya Awareness: An Instagram post shows a finished project made by someone like her. Consideration: The visual narrative and promotional video show the community and experience inside the space.

Will Awareness: A TikTok-style social post shows a real making process in an accessible, energetic format. Consideration: The audio story includes a voice that sounds like his community; the infographic surfaces scholarship and discount programs. Action: The landing page prominently features financial accessibility information and a low-barrier first step.

Linda Awareness: A LinkedIn post or article excerpt frames HackPGH's equity mission in sector-relevant language. Consideration: The infographic presents impact metrics and community reach data; the campaign proposal documents organizational depth. Action: The landing page includes a clear donation or grant inquiry pathway.

Medium-Specific Storytelling Rationale

Audio humanizes the space through voice and the warmth of real people talking about belonging cannot be replicated in text or images alone. Photography captures the coexistence of tools and people, showing that this is a human community and not just an industrial facility. Video is the only medium that can move an audience from problem to resolution in under 90 seconds. The infographic makes equity legible and presents data on loneliness and accessibility, which speaks directly to funders in a format they trust. Social media meets audiences where they already are. We're designing platform-specific content to ensure the message reaches each persona in their own context. A landing page creates coherence because without a central hub, the campaign would feel like disconnected pieces and not a unified story.